FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

The controversy over rewriting history in student curricula is with us again, rekindling a debate that has kept temperatures high around this subject for over two decades. Both politics of the highly charged kind and politics-neutral issues frame the debate. Last June, the NCERT, India's official syllabus-maker, introduced some significant changes, in the context of the Covid-19 pandemic. The National Education Policy, 2020 had formalised a principle that had found consensus all around and been already put into practice: a lighter workload for students. Progressively, since 2017, almost 30 per cent of the syllabi across subjects has been trimmed. Last June, the NCERT said the widespread learning disruptions caused by the lockdowns provided an urgent proximate cause for another round of revisions. Given how students had suffered since 2020, no one would have had any argument with it had it not been for the areas touched on, and the very nature of the changes.

Many of the changes were made public last June and had already stirred a hornet's nest then. A whole chapter on the Mughals was gone, so were references to caste-based inequality under classical Hinduism, and passages on Dalit movements, the Nehruvian era of governance immediately after Independence and the 2002 Gujarat riots. And when the new textbooks for 2023-24 reached students recently, media reports highlighted a few more changes that had been slipped in without being broadcast in public. The most contentious of these were of the same ilk: the description of Mahatma Gandhi's assassin Nathuram Godse as a Brahmin and the editor of a Hindu extremist magazine had been deleted, so had references to past assassination attempts on Gandhi by Hindu extremist groups, and the subsequent ban on the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS).



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Historians and educationists critical of the Narendra Modi government immediately cried foul and saw the revisions as part of an ongoing saffronisation of school curricula. The terms of this debate were set during the first NDA government under A.B. Vajpayee, when Murli Manohar Joshi was the education minister. The BJP-RSS ecosystem, experiencing full power for the first time, had then had its first chance to act on an old pique. They said Indian history-writing, as it evolved during the post-British years, was an act conducted substantially by 'Leftist historians'. And alleging this had left a bias in the books that did not favour 'Hindu ways of thinking', they arrogated to themselves the necessary task of 'correcting wrongs'. And the Congress ecosystem, they said, had always produced an official history that sat well with its own ideological needs too. So they could not complain now. The issue has thus been trapped in a 'your wrong versus my wrong' relativism, often obfuscating the serious question of what exactly should be taught to school students.

In scale, the changes this time are not heavy—the real deal will be the textbooks prepared after the National Curriculum Framework, expected soon. For now, they do not entail substantial 'rewriting' per se, and consist of a small, if loaded, set of deletions. Notwithstanding the defence about Covid-19 warranting lighter textbooks, it would be clear to anyone that the scissors had zeroed in unerringly on topics within history, sociology and political science that are uncomfortable for the Hindu right wing. Or unpalatable in terms of its worldview. Two whole pages on the 2002 Gujarat riots were gone, including the National Human Rights Commission's criticism of the Gujarat government and then PM Vajpayee's "raj dharma" remark. Content related to Mughals and Muslim rule in general, especially of the sort that showed them in positive light, have faced cuts across all classes. The deleted chapter on the Mughals included, for instance, a two-page chart on their achievements, and passages on Akbar's administration, his social and religious policies and his commissioning of translations of Sanskrit works into Persian. The logic advanced was that Mughals had been represented disproportionately in Indian history so far and there was a need for balance that could be achieved by highlighting the many other empires that ruled India like the Cholas, the Marathas, the Vijayanagara and many others.

Critics also cite how various segments on democratic rights and freedoms have been 'rationalised': for instance, popular movements such as Chipko in Uttarakhand, the Dalit Panthers in Maharashtra, the Narmada Bachao Andolan, the run-up to the Right to Information Act, or the recent farmers' agitation. In a delicious irony on many fronts, a section on the Emergency of 1975, too, has faced the censor's scissors, the explanation being whatever was unnecessary or repeated in other classes had been removed. At its root, this is fundamentally a political stand, extraneous to history or any of the other disciplines, and proudly and self-admittedly ideological in its motivations. In its aggressive defence, the BJP cites only how ruling ideologies have always controlled the narrative. That may be true but, by doing the same, it becomes a classic case of 'history repeating itself'.

In this week's cover story, Executive Editor Kaushik Deka presents an exhaustive list of the changes in the textbooks, and talks to all sides on how they perceive it. In a set of two columns, Right-leaning archaeologist Dr Makkhan Lal and Left historians Mridula Mukherjee and Aditya Mukherjee bring their forceful arguments to the table. Over the long term, though, the domain of textbook-writing needs an independent institution staffed by subject experts that insulates it from political demands. The questions that animate it should relate only to what is relevant in the context of teaching schoolchildren. At what grade should they be introduced to some of the complex themes of Indian history? Some of those themes are formative of how we are as a people and a republic. Perhaps, pure objectivity is nearly impossible when it comes to looking at the past. What we need is balance. One cannot be judging the past from the standards of the present. Many shameful events have taken place in the past, but whitewashing them does a disservice to our children. What students must get is a clear, unbiased understanding of Indian history rather than face periodic revisions that create confusion about what actually happened.



(Aroon Purie)